

Discovery Report — VibeHaus

Your vibe. Your people. Your city. · Author: Sakshi · Capstone · 26 August 2026

Evidence base (stated honestly): 1 founder-as-user interview + 3 friend-app survey responses + competitor desk research. Samples are small and expat-skewed — reported as counts, not percentages, and used directionally. This grounds a capstone; it is **not** startup-grade validation, and the limitations are named throughout.

1. Problem framing

Making real friends as an adult — especially after moving to a new city — is hard. Across the research, the pain was consistently about **depth and fit, not access**: people accumulate acquaintances but struggle to find people they genuinely click with. A second, sharp barrier is the **risk of the first move** — you can't tell if the other person wants to connect, so reaching out feels clingy.

What the product can and can't do (honest scoping): the user outcome is meaningful, lasting friendships — but whether two people become lasting friends is outside any app's direct control. VibeHaus's actual job is narrower and achievable: make **higher-quality introductions** and make the **first connection easier**. We design for the outcome; we measure the job.

How Might We: How might we help newcomers in Berlin find people they genuinely click with, and feel confident making the first move — so that casual connections can grow into real friendships?

Opportunity areas (user / product):

1. **Fit-first matching** — match on interests + personality + social energy, not proximity or looks.
2. **Signalled mutual intent** — remove the fear of the first move via mutual opt-in.
3. **Activity-based connection** — help people do things together, not just "be friends."
4. **Explained AI** — make matching trustworthy by showing why, since users are wary of AI.
5. **Safety by design** — mutual opt-in and block/report, because strangers meet offline (identity verification on the roadmap).

(Reaching expats where they gather is a **go-to-market** question, not a product opportunity — see §8.)

2. Competitive snapshot

Selected because they represent different models in the same space. (Desk-research assessment; cells are directional.)

Competitor	Primary model	Fit matching	Mutual intent	Activities	Expat focus
Bumble BFF	Profile + swipe	Medium	Yes	Low	No
Meetup	Interest groups/events	Low	No	High	No
Timeleft	Curated IRL dinners	Medium	N/A	High	No
InterNationals	Expat community + events	Low	Low	High	High
VibeHaus	Fit-first friendship	High	High	Medium → High	High

- **Bumble BFF** — broad, but swipe/appearance-led, thin on fit and intent signal.
- **Meetup** — great for events, weak on personal compatibility and turning a group into friends.
- **Timeleft** — strong curated IRL experiences; not about ongoing 1:1 friendship or choosing your people.
- **InterNations** — the largest expat network (420 cities), event- and community-first with hundreds of monthly events; no compatibility/fit engine, membership by application.
- **Positioning:** where others are swipe-first, event-first, or community-first, **VibeHaus is fit-first** — it matches on personality + social energy + intent, explains the match, and requires mutual opt-in so reaching out feels safe. Expat-first, with Events (public/private meetups) built into the MVP alongside the core matching flow.

2b. Problem map — current vs proposed journey

Current journey (today's tools): want friends in a new city → join Meetup / Bumble BFF / groups → browse or swipe (appearance-led, little sense of fit) → hope the other person is open (fear of "clingy") → meet at an event/coffee → **rarely sticks**.

Core gap: no low-pressure way to connect on your own terms — chat, coffee, or a shared activity — instead of a forced, dating-style chat-first path.

Existing tools force a single path: dating-style apps match you, then drop you into a one-to-one chat that can feel like an awkward, interview-like exchange — while group-event tools ask you to walk into a room of strangers, which is its own kind of pressure. People connect differently: some want to build trust slowly through messages at their own pace (especially introverts), while others would rather skip the small talk and simply do something together. The gap is a way to meet that lets each person **choose their own on-ramp — chat, coffee, or a shared activity** — with no pressure to perform a conversation before a friendship has any reason to exist.

Proposed journey (VibeHaus) — hypothesised, to validate: describe your vibe (interests · social energy · intent) → VibeHaus recommends people who fit → shows a **banded Vibe Score with a short "why you might vibe"** → you browse a scrollable feed and react **privately**: tap the **heart** to like a profile, which opens a choice — **"Send Vibemate Request"** (literally sends the request, the heart fills to show it) or **"Maybe Later"** (does not send a request, instead saves the profile to **Saved Vibes** to revisit anytime) — or tap the **bookmark** directly to save a profile the same way, without going through the heart at all, or simply scroll past to skip, with nothing recorded → a sent Vibemate Request needs mutual accept → **Vibemates**, auto-added to **My Haus** → **Chat** unlocks; **Coffee Vibe / Activity Vibe** can be suggested (each with its own accept, and either side can cancel a confirmed one) → a real conversation, and maybe a real meet-up, begins. Principle: increasing intimacy requires increasing consent. Events (public/private meetups) and a chip-based assistant, Mr. Vibe, are also built into the MVP, not future items. Future: learning-over-time matching, real identity verification, a fully live-conversational Mr. Vibe.

2c. Product idea — worked examples

- **"I'm new to Berlin and want people who like hiking and quiet weekends."** → VibeHaus surfaces fellow newcomers with outdoors + chill social energy; each card shows a banded score + one-line reason; she likes two, both accept, a chat opens with a suggested Icebreaker.
- **"I want deeper friendships, not a going-out crew."** → the social-energy signal ("keep it chill") weights matches toward meaningful-conversation types over nightlife — directly answering the "depth, not access" pain.

3. User understanding

Proto-persona — Newcomer Nadia (a hypothesis-based representation informed by early discovery, to be validated and refined through further interviews): 30s expat, 0–3 years in Berlin, basic German, ambivert. Has acquaintances but few genuine friends; wants meaningful connection without huge effort; wary a friend-app might "feel like dating."

- **Goals:** find people she genuinely clicks with; connect at her own pace; do real things together.
- **Pains:** poor fit / settling; fear of the first move; casual meets that don't stick; wanting depth without huge effort in her 30s.

JTBD:

- When I've moved somewhere new, I want to find people I genuinely click with, so I build real friendships, not acquaintances.
- When I want to reach out, I want to know they're open too, so I don't feel clingy.
- When I meet someone promising, I want to choose how we connect (chat/coffee/activity), so it fits my comfort.
- As an ambivert, I want to message first, so trust can build before meeting.

4. Research approach

- **Interview** (behaviour-anchored, non-leading): 1 in-depth, founder-as-user (flagged).
- **Survey** (12 questions, bias-audited): 3 responses from expats who had tried ways to meet people.
- **Competitor desk research:** the landscape above.
- **AI simulation / assumptions to validate:** depth-not-access is the core pain; mutual opt-in makes reaching out feel safe; users accept AI matching if explained. (Insert any formal AI-simulation notes here if run.)
- **Next with real users:** interview introverts and people who arrived alone; recruit non-expats to test breadth; usability-test the core flow.

Assumptions → what real users must validate

Assumption (from discovery)	What real users must confirm
Depth, not access, is the core pain	Do people beyond my network describe the same "nothing sticks" frustration?
Existing tools fall short	Have they tried Meetup/Bumble BFF here and found it didn't lead to real friendship?

Mutual opt-in removes the first-move fear

Does knowing the other person opted in make them more willing to reach out?

Explained matches build trust

Does "why you'd vibe" beat an unexplained recommendation?

Curated fit beats browsing/swiping

Do they prefer recommended fits over scrolling profiles?

Pain is real but not urgent

Would they actually sign up and return — or is it a quiet wish? (activation risk)

Success signals to look for (in upcoming usability testing)

(Early validation signals, not business KPIs.)

Hypothesis	Validation signal
<i>Users understand Vibe Match</i>	<i>They can explain, in their words, why someone was recommended</i>
<i>Explained matching builds trust</i>	<i>They prefer a match with a reason over one without</i>
<i>Mutual intent reduces anxiety</i>	<i>They report greater willingness to make the first move</i>
<i>Connection modes reduce friction</i>	<i>They confidently pick chat / coffee / activity</i>

It doesn't feel like dating

*They describe it as friendship/social discovery,
unprompted*

*Recommendations feel
relevant*

*They name at least one person they'd genuinely want to
meet*

*Discovery interviews validate the problem; prototype usability testing validates the solution —
separate steps.*

4b. Secondary research — external evidence

*Beyond our 1 interview + 3 survey responses, published data shows the underlying problem is
large, measurable, and specific to Berlin/Germany — not just anecdotal.*

- **Loneliness is acute in Berlin specifically — and tied to our exact triggers.** A 2025 review of Berlin loneliness initiatives notes the city leans on only ~1,300 volunteers across loneliness projects for its 3.6M residents, and Berlin's CDU has proposed a "Commissioner for Loneliness." Citing a **2024 Techniker Krankenkasse survey, 68% of people aged 18–39 in Germany report having experienced loneliness** — often linked to **living alone, moving cities, or changing jobs** (VibeHaus's precise trigger moments). → <https://foreveryone.berlin/blog/loneliness-in-berlin/>
- **Making friends in Germany is measurably hard for newcomers.** InterNations' Expat Insider "Finding Friends" ranking placed **Germany 47th of 58 countries** for making friends, after three years in the global bottom 10. In Germany only **~16% of expats are mainly friends with locals**, while **~39% are mainly friends with other expats** — the common refrain: "easy to make expat friends, hard to make German friends." Globally, **only ~42% of expats find it easy to make local friends.** → iamexpat.de / InterNations: <https://www.iamexpat.de/expat-info/germany-news/germany-ranked-one-worst-countries-world-making-friends>
- **Young adults in Germany are widely lonely.** A 2024 Bertelsmann Stiftung study found **51% of young German adults (18–35) are at least moderately lonely** (12% severely). → <https://www.bertelsmann-stiftung.de/en/our-projects/next-generation-and-society/project-news/a-comparison-of-youth-loneliness-in-europe-in-2024>
- **Loneliness has persisted post-pandemic.** Germany's **Federal Institute for Population Research (BiB)** 2024–25 "Freda" study found **just over 1 in 5 people aged 21–30 feel very lonely** (14% among 31–54), with loneliness "barely receded since the pandemic." → <https://www.bib.bund.de> (reported: <https://www.yahoo.com/news/world/articles/study-one-five-young-germans-131137022.html>)

What this adds to our primary data: our interview + survey pointed to depth over access and that existing tools fall short; the secondary data confirms the **scale and persistence of the problem** — forming real friendships as a newcomer/young adult in Germany is a large, documented pain, concentrated in exactly our target group. Honest limit: this validates the **problem**, not our specific **solution** (AI matching + chat/coffee/activity) — that differentiation still needs primary validation.

5. Key insights

Patterns / themes (early, directional):

- **Depth, not access** — appeared in the interview and all three survey open-texts ("nothing stuck," wanting "longterm trust"); directional, not yet broadly validated.
- **Fit over quantity** — 8–10 acquaintances but only 1–2 real friends.
- **The first-move risk** — reaching out feels clingy without a signal of mutual interest.
- **Existing tools often fall short** — 2 of 3 who tried them found they didn't lead to lasting friendship (1 succeeded via curated groups).
- **Curated groups/activities preferred over profile-browsing** — 3/3 in the survey.
- **AI interest lukewarm** — welcomed by some, not a pull → AI must be explained, not hyped.

Emotional needs: to reach out without seeming needy; to find people who get them (belonging in a new city); to build friendship at a comfortable pace (esp. ambiverts/introverts); to feel safe (a woman's safety concern was explicit).

Gaps in current options: no fit-first matching; no signal of mutual intent; casual meets don't become friendships; browsing feels superficial; safety/"not-dating" reassurance missing.

Risks / assumptions: founder-as-user bias; small, expat-skewed sample (no introverts/locals yet); pain real but not urgent (activation risk); "feels like dating" trap; two-sided/empty-app problem; AI value unproven.

6. Recommendations (prioritised)

App / digital features: fit-first **Vibe Match** on interests + social energy + intent; a **banded Vibe Score** always shown with a short "why you might vibe" listing every genuinely shared interest (e.g. "Strong Vibe 🌟 — both new to Berlin, into hiking, prefer small groups") — never an unexplained precise percentage; a scrollable feed with private **like/save** (scrolling past skips, no explicit "dislike") instead of swiping; Like → **Vibemate Request / Maybe Later** → mutual accept → **Vibemates in My Haus**; **Chat** auto-unlocks, **Coffee Vibe / Activity Vibe** available as separate, further-consent suggestions, either party can cancel; personality-first profiles with optional fields (languages, hometown/country, new-in-town — no ethnicity); **Events built** (public/private, cancel/leave) and **Calendar** merging both, plus **Mr. Vibe** (chip-based assistant) — all fully implemented, not roadmap.

Vibe Match — how it works (hypothesised): recommendations combine **shared interests · social energy (1:1 vs small vs large) · friendship intent · lifestyle/availability · connection preference**, then present a compatible person with a **human-readable reason**. No opaque profiling, no persistent training in the MVP.

Human support / safety (people, not just tech): **block, report, and remove-Vibemate are part of the MVP** (strangers meet offline, so basic safety can't be "later"); no contact of any kind before mutual Vibemate acceptance; community guidelines. **Identity verification is deliberately kept off the MVP** — a "Verified" badge would imply a check that isn't performed — and sits on the Next roadmap alongside automated moderation, event-host reputation, and safety check-ins.

Notifications / reminders (role & principles): re-engagement for a low-frequency behaviour — a new Vibe Match, a pending request, a suggested activity. Opt-in, relevant, never spammy.

Education (what users must learn): it's not a dating app and reaching out is safe because it's mutual; how the AI matches (transparency builds trust); a gentle newcomer onboarding.

Escalation (when & how): uncertain AI output → fall back to filters; safety issues → in-app block/report/remove (MVP) plus the mutual-opt-in gate; sensitive fields kept optional and non-filterable; automated moderation and verification are the next safety layer.

6b. MVP at a glance

(Full scope + acceptance criteria in the backlog & PRD; summary here for traceability.) **Must-have:** onboarding (interests · social energy · intent · connection preference) · personality-first profile (optional fields: languages, hometown/country, new-in-town) · AI **Vibe Match** cards with a banded, explained score listing all shared interests · **light expat-aware matching (newcomer status + shared-language soft-boost) + newcomer icebreaker** · private like/save · **Vibemate Request** → **mutual accept** → **My Haus** · **Chat** (auto-unlock, photo + tappable name) + **Coffee Vibe / Activity Vibe** (separate accept, either party can cancel) · **safety: block / report / remove Vibemate** (checked live, not cached) · **Events** (public/private, open-to-all/permission-based, cancel/leave) · **Calendar** (merges Coffee/Activity Vibes + Events) · **Mr. Vibe** (chip-based activity-search assistant, see §7 of the AI Responsibility Statement for why it's chip-only, not free-text). **Not MVP (expat vision → roadmap):** newcomer cohort, city-orientation activities & newcomer meetups, local-guide/buddy matching, language-pairing as a first-class axis · a fully free-text/live-generative Mr. Vibe · advanced AI learning / a trained recommender · identity verification · live map integration · group matching · gamification · premium tier.

7. Where this leaves the decision

The friend app rests on a **promising differentiation hypothesis** (fit + signalled mutual intent), with **early directional evidence** from both the interview and survey pointing to "depth, not

access," a **rich, explainable AI story**, and a clear demoable MVP. Its weaknesses — thin, founder-skewed discovery and a not-urgent, two-sided pain — are named openly and addressed by seeding, a usability test, and tight scope. On balance it is the stronger capstone: **VibeHaus is the chosen direction.**

8. Market & distribution hypothesis

(Go-to-market, not product — hypotheses to validate, not proven channels.) Beachhead: international newcomers in Berlin. Channels to test: expat Facebook/WhatsApp communities, universities, coworking spaces, language exchanges, international professional groups, Berlin newcomer groups. These are **assumptions**, not validated acquisition channels.